



M **ROSS** CAREER DEVELOPMENT OFFICE

GUIDE TO: THE MBA RESUME

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Role of the Resume for Two Purposes:

1. To help them get to know you when networking
2. To determine whether you meet their qualifications when deciding who to interview

A good resume will advance your personal narrative by connecting your previous experience to their job qualifications. Additionally, during coffee chats and behavioral interviews, it will frame those conversations and lead to questions that demonstrate your experience and strengths. The resume is your personal marketing document to position yourself for the role.

CRAFTING YOUR MBA RESUME



Your MBA resume will likely be much different from resumes you have created in the past. Most first-year MBAs will spend substantial time retooling their resumes. Below is a summary of the resume creation process.

1 Know Your Brand

Your resume is a part of a broader marketing effort that bridges what you have done to what you want to do. Recruiters are looking for a succinct, coherent, and consistent story that connects the dots for them – this is your brand.

ACTION: Look to [Page 4](#) of this guide where you will learn about using the resume to tell your story.

2 Focus on Achievement + Impact

An MBA-level resume focuses on the impact that you have had in your previous roles to demonstrate leadership potential and business acumen for your future roles. Companies are excited by candidates who can show a clear record of accomplishment for their employers.

ACTION: Look to [Page 7](#) of this guide where you will learn how to construct strong ACR (Action-Context-Results) resume bullets.

3 Use iMPact to Develop Your Resume

On-campus resumes live in iMPact, which has a program that you should use for your general or “Default” resume. Your “Default” resume will allow employers to access your resume during the on-campus job search process. Impact also lets you easily update and tailor your resume to multiple roles and creates all the formatting for you.

ACTION: Learn how to use Impact in the “[Entering Your Resume on Impact](#)” document.

4 Think about Your Off-Campus Resume

CDO recommends that incoming MBAs pursue off-campus job opportunities in addition to going through the on-campus process. Ross has a large and helpful alumni network, most of whom work for companies that do not come to campus. Off-campus resumes do not necessarily have to be written in iMPact. You are allowed more latitude to build your off-campus resume in terms of creativity with formatting, length, what information you include, etc.

ACTION: [Click here](#) to learn more about Off-campus resumes, see templates, and access other resources for your off-campus search.

Using Ross Resources to Perfect Your Resume

Ross CDO has provided numerous resources to guide you through writing your resume and perfecting it to ensure it is employer ready. Perfecting your resume is a time-intensive process, and we are excited to set you up for success with your dream organizations.

Key resources include:

- Recruiting Prep Course
- CDO FACT Groups
- CDO Staff and Peer Coach Appointments
- CDO Reference Guides
- Student Career Clubs
- Online tools such as AI

Action: Look to [Page 9](#) of this guide where we have provided a generalized timeline to use these resources to create a finalized resume in time for networking and resume drops.



Reading Job Descriptions

Creating a great resume requires knowing what types of skills and experience a particular industry/function/role requires. Start by asking an AI tool such as ChatGPT for the typical qualifications of a job. The more specific you can be the better: e.g. - "List the typical job requirements for an MBA product manager at Amazon" will yield more accurate results than "List the typical job requirements for a tech product manager," and much more useful results than "List the typical job requirements for a product manager." It's also important to read a few actual job descriptions to validate any results you get from an AI tool. Knowing the qualifications for the jobs in which you're interested is the key ingredient for focusing your story and aligning it to the job.

Your goal is to list the skills, experience, and traits that have been spelled out in the job description for which you are applying.

Evaluating Your Story

Most MBAs are looking to switch careers. Recruiters understand this and will generally not require direct industry experience. However, your resume must clearly articulate transferable skills that are relevant to the position's job description.

Reframing your experience can be challenging, particularly for students who come from non-business backgrounds. CDO can help you with this. We recommend (1) using an AI tool such as ChatGPT to help you understand how your experience relates to what you want to do next: e.g. - "How would my experience as an Auditor help me be an effective Product Manager?" (2) meeting with a CDO Peer Coach in a comparable job to discuss your background and identify the achievements that will best advocate your case, and (3) setting up a resume review with a CDO Career Coach.

Your goal is to understand how what you've done qualifies you for what you want to do next.

Synthesizing Your Story

After you have taken these steps, you are ready to start creating your resume.

For MBA level recruiting, your goal is not to describe everything you've done, but to choose the best situations that show relevant skills and accomplishments for the job while fitting into the narrative that you want to tell about why your experience logically progresses to this role.

MBA Resume Structure:

The MBA resume contains three main sections – **Education/Experience/Additional** – which provide different opportunities to advocate for yourself.

		NAME (MBA1)		1
		Street Address City, STATE Zip (Optional)		2
		emailaddress@umich.edu 999.000.0000		
15 - 25%	EDUCATION	UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN	Ann Arbor, MI	
	3	Stephen M. Ross School of Business Master of Business Administration, April 2028		4
		- Emphases in Marketing and Corporate Strategy - Elected Co-President of the Marketing Club - Selected as Corporate Liaison for Annual Marketing Symposium - Marketing Coordinator, Dell Case Competition		
		UNIVERSITY OF VIRGINIA	Charlottesville, VA	
	6	College of Arts and Sciences Bachelor of Arts in Marketing, May 2020		5
		- Graduated with Honors, 3.7/ 4.0 - Elected Student Government class representative - Elected Social Chair of Kappa Kappa Gamma National Sorority		
60 - 70%	EXPERIENCE	DELL COMPUTER CO.	Austin, TX	
	7	Senior Account Manager (2024-2026)		
	8	Led team in online sales management, systematic team building, and performance metrics implementation, exceeded team sales quota by average of 28% each year		
	9	- Fostering successful cooperation between marketing and sales departments leading to new product launches and promotions and \$12M of new revenue. - Analyzed opportunities to increase profit margins leading to implementation of new pricing policy for low-volume retailers which increasing the margin by 3% for this group. - Trained over 100 marketing operations employees on execution of local advertising program leading to 70% improved compliance with corporate advertising guidelines.		
		Account Manager (2022-2024)		
		- Developed innovative promotion for new product lines targeting college campuses and high schools in sales region resulting in increase in sales revenue of \$2 million. - Created analytical model to identify accounts with high sales potential and prioritize sales effort using proprietary metrics resulting in 17% increase in sales close rate. - Conducted online campaign that increased online sales contribution from 13% to 34%, achieved "Top Salesperson" award and "Award of Excellence".		
	2020-2022	CDW	Atlanta, GA	
		Account Representative		
		- Prospected and managed new and existing customer relationships for over 75 accounts to develop customized computer hardware and software solutions increasing account base by 38% during 20-month period - Collaborated with creative department to create attention-grabbing point-of-sales material increasing lead generation by 8% and adopted by regional office for wide-spread use. - Mentored four other sales representatives in the areas of understanding customer needs, developing new business leads and increasing revenues through cross-selling; Achieved 2002 top salesperson of regional office.		
10 - 15%	ADDITIONAL	10	Lived with a family in Colombia for 6 months to acquire conversational Spanish skills	
		11	Enjoy cross-country skiing, music festivals, and giving impromptu salsa lessons	

RESUME FLASH POINTS:

- If you prefer a nickname, include it in parentheses after your formal name Include your email and phone number; physical address is optional
- Spell out degree
- Include proper concentrations, specializations, emphasis (if one) or emphases (if two)
- Include GPA if exceptional. Include GMAT if 90% or higher
- Involvement shows where your interests lie, so mention relevant activities in which you are involved
- Put experiences in reverse chronological order to show progression in career Use ACR (Action, Context, Result) format for experience bullets
- Allocate more bullets and space to the job roles which are more relevant to the job you are seeking Include specific, unique skills, interests, and experiences to make yourself more memorable.
- Include language proficiencies, relevant technical capabilities, work certifications, etc.

Header: The header gives general information about your name and how to contact you. Impact will require you to include your address, phone number, and email address.

- **Name:** If you are called by a name that is not a derivative of your given name, put it in parentheses after your first name.
- **Address:** Optional, but if you include it, you should use your Ann Arbor address for on-campus recruiting. For off-campus, you can use a local address in your target city, Ann Arbor, or whatever location works for you.
- **Email Address:** You should use your UMich email address on your resume.

Education: The purpose of the education section is to demonstrate the brands of and degrees from the schools you have attended, the quality of your career as a student, and the relevance to the role you are considering.

- **Degree:** Spell out “Master of Business Administration, May [YEAR].”
- **Academic Concentrations, Specializations, or Emphases:** Add your academic focus on your first education line to indicate interests and academic depth relevant to the roles to which you will apply. These are subjects (strategy/finance) rather than careers (consulting/investment banking). You can include up to two. Because concentrations and specializations are monitored by the program office, they are stronger than emphases which simply indicate you intend to or have taken extra electives in that subject matter.
- **Grades/GMAT Scores:** Include your GPA for undergrad and GMAT scores if they are exceptional (e.g.- above 3.5 GPA, 90th percentil or above GMAT) or if your in-dustry/function requires it. Generally, you will not need to include it on your resume. Your Ross GPA should not be on your resume.
- **Academic Honors:** Demonstrate your academic success if you are on track to graduate “With Distinction” or “With High Distinction.” Follow the [Ross Guidelines](#) and/or those of your undergraduate school.
- **Club Activities:** Show leadership, management, and/or functional skills through your Ross activities. Exclude activities if your club involvement at Ross does not bolster your narrative. The general format for leadership is “Elected/Selected [ROLE] of [CLUB].”
- **Case Competitions:** Show business acumen and success by including case competitions that you have won or placed highly that are relevant to the job you seek.

Experience: This section demonstrates the work skills that you have attained in your career relevant to the position for which you are applying. The experience section is the most pivotal section – you should spend most of your time ensuring it shows your impressive work history.

- **ACR Bullet Points:** Orient your experience to concrete impact that your actions have made for your previous employers. Page 7 outlines how to construct good ACR bullet points.
- **Two-Line Bullets:** Write concise ACR bullet points that convey your message. Generally two lines is ideal to show Action, Context, and Results, although 1-3 can be appropriate.
- **Bullet Count:** Show multiple facets of your previous roles by writing several bullet points. The sweet spot is 2-5 bullets per role, but in certain cases you might have no bullets or just 1, and if you only had one position in one job, you may have more than 5.
- **Bullet Order:** Your roles should be listed in reverse chronological order and bullets ordered from most significant to least for a particular role. This structure allows recruiters to gain a high-level understanding of your experience quickly.
- **Number Formatting:** CDO recommends that you use Arabic numerals for all numbers in order to save space and make your quantitative results stand out.
- **Simple Language:** You should avoid jargon as much as possible to ensure that the recruiter understands each bullet. Assume the reader has no pertinent industry knowledge to understand jargon.

Additional: The additional section gives you space to add more context to who you are outside of your career. The best additional bullets are both interesting and convey a trait that is relevant. This section is an opportunity to show specific aspects of your personality and define yourself to recruiters before you meet them. Good additional sections can lead to questions about your interests and humanize you to representatives of the companies to which you apply.

- **Show Passion:** Many additional sections include basic interests without showing excitement about their interests. Instead of saying “interested in cooking,” for example, you could say “spent two years mastering Szechuan culinary techniques to create communal home cooking experiences for friends.” The latter shows depth and passion that makes you stand out.
- **Avoid Clichés:** Many MBA students could better maximize this section by avoiding common interests that do not stand out. Examples include travel, skiing, running, etc. Present a brief unique story in the additional section related to these interests rather than general ones.



WRITING GREAT ACR BULLET POINTS



Action-Context-Results Format:

CDO recommends ACR as the way to structure your experience bullets on your resume. When written well, ACR structure allows recruiters and hiring managers to quickly understand the relevant skills you're bringing to the table, that you utilized those skills in situations to which they can relate, and that you added value. To facilitate reading through them quickly, on-campus and off-campus recruiters look for standardized bullets. To get started, paste your resume into an AI tool such as ChatGPT and ask it to convert it to ACR format.

Example ACR Bullet Point:

Analyzed high scrap rate issue during **vehicle dashboard manufacturing process**, findings contributed to actions **reducing scrap rate from 50% to 10%.**

Action: The Action part of the bullet shows the skill that you utilized to achieve results and highlights your message to the recruiter.	• Start with an <u>action verb</u> that conveys a skill you used to achieve the result. • Avoid beginning with a result verb if possible, because this will bury your role in creating action (reduced, increased, resulted in, etc.). • Use past tense unless the task is ongoing at your current job.
Context: The Context portion serves to provide the reader with an adequate sense of why your action mattered for your organization.	Important items to consider include: • Business Rationale: What problem did you address? • The Scope: How did you define this problem in terms of size, budget, people, revenue, cost, etc? Outlining the scope is important in most business projects and demonstrates the relative importance of your work. • The Significance: Why did this project or activity matter to the organization? A project with critical and high-stakes scope will look impressive to your potential employers. • Avoid "by statements" that add additional actions. Context should convey that you utilized the action in circumstances similar to those you would encounter with your prospective employer, not how you did the action presented at the beginning of the bullet.
Result: The Results section shows your personal impact for the organization and therefore your potential to impact your future employers.	• Quantitative vs. Qualitative Results: Both types of results are great, and you can include both on your resume. Many MBAs mistakenly think that only quantitative results matter. Use your best examples of the skills you want to present even if the results are qualitative. • Estimates: If you don't have an actual metric, but you can make a reasonable estimate, that's fine. • Expected Results: For a current job or current tasks, expected results can be identified as such. For example, "targeting key segments that are expected to grow revenue by \$7 million" would be a fine result for an ongoing project.

RESUME BEST PRACTICES

Use Your One Page Strategically: You have one page to include the best information about yourself that demonstrates your qualifications for a given job. Every line should build on your narrative.

- **Dangling Words onto Next Line:** Avoid dangling words that add an extra line onto the resume. If you have a line that only has 1-2 words, edit so that you reduce it onto the previous line.
- **Balance Your Sections:** Generally speaking, your experience section should take at least 50% of the real estate on your resume. Up to 70-80% is great, providing you have relevant experience to share. The education section should take no more than 30% of your resume, while the additional section provides the remaining ~5 lines. More important, though, is the overall story, so it's okay to vary from these guidelines and allocate space as you see fit.
- **Fill Up the Page:** Before you finalize your resume, try to fill up the page, but if you can't, don't worry about it. Once you add MAP and your internship, you'll have plenty of material to fill up the page.

Tailor Your Resume: Most MBAs will recruit in multiple functions and/or industries and must alter their resume accordingly. These alterations put the most relevant foot forward to your potential employer so that they understand your story about why you are pursuing the role. Remember that recruiters look through hundreds of resumes – you will stand out if you show pertinent experience and passion for the role. For off-campus job searches especially, tailoring is critically important to grabbing a recruiter's interest. Copying your resume and a specific job description into an AI tool such as ChatGPT and asking it for feedback is a quick way to get ideas to craft a more tailored resume.

Avoid Job Description Bullets: Before Ross, most people had resumes that bulleted their responsibilities rather than their skills and achievements. At the MBA level, employers want to know that you understand what you will do for them, not what you did for your previous employer. Actions that convey relevant skills, context that conveys utilizing those skills in situations to which your prospective employer can relate, and results that show you added value will allow you to stand out and show your unique strengths.

Cut (most) Accolades/Awards/Certifications from Experience: Depending on your previous career, these items might have been useful on your resume to show your skillset and your successes. In the MBA context, employers are looking for general business and leadership skills with relevance to the function and/or industry. Use accolades, awards, and certifications only if they are relevant to the new job. For example, if you are a CPA, that certification may be relevant in Corporate Finance or Banking, but not important to include if you are pursuing Marketing. An award might be appropriate, but do not mistake it for the result of your action.

Stay away from Unnecessary Punctuation: Many MBAs in their initial drafts will have bullets where the results are separated by semi-colons, periods, or commas. CDO recommends avoiding this practice as it tends to make resume bullets longer and unclear. You want one unified idea rather than several disjointed sentences/clauses.

Don't Write Promotion Bullets: Your promotions are demonstrated with your career progression on your resume. Adding a bullet point about your promotion takes space that you could use to develop your story.

Approximate and Round Quantitative Figures: It is preferable to approximate large-scale figures rather than giving the exact number. For example, if you had a project that saved \$1,567,382, you can round to \$1.6 million. Make sure to be consistent with like numbers, while using common sense to round to the most accurate figure.

Be Specific: Oftentimes, MBAs will round in their resume and write “~1.5 million” or “1.5 million +” to quantify results, instead of simply stating “1.5 million.” Using approximations or ranges tends to express doubt, particularly in highly quantitative fields. Employers are looking for people who can identify exact figures and can express it confidently to their coworkers. Avoid sounding insecure with wishy-washy numbers.

Consider Removing Your Academic Publications from Education Section: Many MBAs have a body of academic work that is irrelevant to the careers they seek. In the MBA context, employers would rather see real life experience rather than academic study. Your work history will be more impressive to recruiters than your academic work. Adding academic work in the additional section may be appropriate.

Be Concise with Context: Many MBA students, particularly those who have unusual or nuanced careers, add too much context into their bullets at the expense of showing action and results.

Don't Disregard Qualitative Results: Although many industries such as consulting or banking look for quantitative skill-sets, qualitative results like influencing and enabling leadership to achieve a goal, etc. also are important to these roles. Many MBA students erroneously drop qualitative results thinking that companies only want to see numeric results. You should use the results on your resume that best advance your narrative.

Use Your MAP/LBLE Experience: If your MAP or LBLE experience is relevant to the job/function you seek, include it on your resume. Follow the [Action Based Learning and Impact Resume Format Quick Tips](#) for guidance on adding these programs to your resume.

Update Your Resume: Your resume is a dynamic and living document that will change over the course of your business school career and thereafter. You can update it with new information throughout your two years at Ross. Most MBAs will recruit on-campus during MBA1, and on-and off-campus during MBA2. Keeping your resume fresh will help you better craft stories for your networking and interviews as well.

Listen to Your Instincts: This guide and all the help that you will receive from CDO Staff and Peer Coaches are general guidelines to help you. Of course, you know your brand better than anyone – all these choices for your resume are your decisions. If you receive conflicting advice or want to bend these rules, that is ok. No guideline fits everyone, and it is important for you to do what feels right and makes you most confident.

RESUME TIMELINE + CHECKLIST

MBA1 Timeline

☐ PRE-MBA SUMMER

It's tempting to jump into tactical mode and start editing your resume, but a great resume and successful recruiting effort is built on a more strategic foundation. To build a strong foundation, complete Modules 1-3 of the CDO Recruiting Prep Course:

- Module 1 will get you set up in the Ross Recruit system and help you understand the MBA recruiting journey
- Module 2 will help you reflect on career options. This is important to complete to help you avoid FOMO, even if you're certain you know what you want to do for work after you get your MBA.
- Module 3 will help you explore your career options. This is important both so that you have a plan B and so that you don't have any regrets.

- ☐ Once you've completed the self-reflection and career exploration steps above, you'll be ready for Module 4 of the CDO Recruiting Prep Course which will help you begin to "MBA-ize" your brand. This includes guidance on updating your resume.

Finally, CDO programming during orientation will help you better understand your resume from the recruiter perspective

SEPTEMBER

- ☐ Use your FACT group and appointments with CDO Staff and Peer Coaches to review your resume as needed (1-3 appointments is typical). Resume reviews can take many forms, and you should be clear with your reviewer about your goals for the session. Common goals include:
- **Narrative Building:** Define your brand and shape your resume for specific functions and industries
 - **Clarity + Power:** Ensure your bullets are relevant and stated as powerfully as possible
 - **Phrasing/Grammar/Spelling:** Take advantage of the Ross Communication Consultants if you feel your writing skills need work, have friends ensure there are no typos!
 - **Finalization:** Get a final resume review from a staff coach or peer coach before they become visible to recruiters at the beginning of October

OCTOBER

- ☐ Finalize your resume and publish for recruiters to view. You know your resume is complete when your advice is small in scope and stylistic rather than content-driven. [Check here for a final checklist.](#)

DECEMBER

- ☐ Update resume ahead of application deadlines
- ☐ **November - January:** On-campus resume drops

SPRING

- ☐ **March - June:** Off-campus applications

MBA2 Timeline

- ☐ Around the midpoint of your internship, reflect on your goals for second year, whether it is staying in your current company/role/function, what works and is challenging about your internship, etc., and make a plan for MBA2 recruiting.

AUGUST

- ☐ Set up a resume review with CDO Career Coach to ensure your resume is ready for on-campus recruiting (this is optional) before MBA2 resumes go live for recruiters

SEPTEMBER

- ☐ On-campus resume drops

DECEMBER - GRADUATION

- ☐ Update resumes for off-campus searches, and use CDO Staff Coaches and Peer Coaches to ensure you are ready to network and apply for off-campus roles